Wishes and Regrets

Activity Sheet (page 1/2)

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Intermediate

We use **wish/if only + past simple/continuous** to talk about present situations which we want to be different.
We use **wish/if only + past perfect** to express regret, or to talk about things we wish had happened differently in the past.
We use **wish/if only + would/wouldn't** to complain about a situation, thing or person which is annoying us.

A. Read the sentences in bold below and decide whether they are referring to the present or the past. Write either 'present' or 'past' in the space provided.

a. **I wish I was taller.** I'd love to be a supermodel. ..... present .....

b. **I wish I had eaten breakfast.** I'm absolutely starving. .....past.....

c. **If only it would stop raining.** I want to go outside. ..... present .....

d. The bus still hasn't arrived. **If only we had driven.** .....past.....

e. **I wish I was an only child.** My sister is so annoying. ..... present .....

B. Complete the sentences by circling the correct tense.

1. If only I *didn't eat* / *hadn't eaten* so much cake at the party. I feel quite ill now.

2. I wish I *lived* / *had lived* in the countryside. I'm fed up with city life.

3. I wish I *didn't shave* / *hadn't shaved* off all my hair. My head is cold.

4. If only our lessons *were* / *had been* shorter. They make me sleepy!

5. I wish he *stopped* / *would stop* coughing. It's really irritating.

C. Complete the sentences on the right so that they have the same meaning as the ones on the left.

1. I would like to live alone. I wish I lived alone. .....

2. I hate my name. I want a different one. If only I had a different name. .....

3. I wasn't careful enough. I regret it. I wish I had been more careful. .....

4. She bites her nails. It's annoying. I wish she wouldn't bite her nails. .....

5. Jen lied. Now she regrets it. If only she hadn't lied. .....

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D. Complete the sentences using one of the verbs in the box below in the correct tense.

bring	**be**	**not / come**	**not / drink**	**have**
slow down	**not / be**	**stop**	**stay**	**understand**

1. Peter wishes his wife were ..... a better cook. She can't even make an omelette.
2. He's driving too fast. I wish he would slow down .....
3. I wish I hadn't come ..... by car. The roads are icy tonight, and parking was expensive.
4. Sally wishes she had ..... a garden. She'd love to grow her own vegetables.
5. I wish I hadn't drunk ..... so much coffee today. I'll never get to sleep.
6. I wish he would stop ..... calling me. I don't want to speak to him.
7. If only I understood ..... Japanese. If I did, I'd know what they were talking about.
8. We wish our parents weren't ..... so strict. They don't let us do anything.
9. If only the bar stayed ..... open later. I don't think I'll make it before closing time.
10. I wish I had brought ..... an umbrella with me. It's pouring!

E. Read the prompts below and complete the sentences next to them with your own endings. Write about:

1. A superpower you would like to have. I wish I could teleport anywhere. .....
2. A possession you would like to own. I wish I owned a small camper van. .....
3. Something you regret doing as a child. I wish I hadn't given up the guitar. .....
4. Something you wish a family member wouldn't do. I wish my brother wouldn't shout. .....
5. A country you would like to live in. I wish I lived in Norway. .....
6. Something you wish you had done in the past. I wish I had studied more English. .....
7. A regret about a purchase you made. I wish I hadn't bought this phone. .....
8. A skill you would like to have. I wish I could speak Japanese. .....
9. Something you wish was different about your home. I wish my flat had a terrace. .....
10. Something about yourself you would like to change. I wish I were more patient. .....

Ask your partner questions to find out what their endings to the sentences were, (e.g., 'What superpower would you like to have?', 'What do you wish a family member wouldn't do?') and find out if any of your endings were similar.

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